

Could trees make Gozo net zero?

The afforestation in the Nationalist Party's 2026 pledge, tested on measured forests and Gozo's land

THE CLAIM

“... every unit of emissions generated is reduced or offset”, afforestation included.

Partit Nazzjonalista, programme Nifs Ġdid (May 2026), Ġhawdex item 46 (our translation)

Goal: Gozo a Net-Zero Island by 2040. The plan itself is Claim Check 107.

News said “through afforestation” and reported an indigenous-tree strategy; neither is in the programme.

PLEDGE

NOT MEASURABLE

No area, species, rate or date.

NOT MEASURABLE

NOT YET DUE

ON TRACK

OFF TRACK

MET

MISSED

MAIN RESULTS

4.9–6.3×

Gozo's area as new forest

Needed to offset its energy CO₂ (118–154 kt a year) by trees alone, at a measured dry-forest rate.

3–4%

If all semi-natural land

All 1,270 ha of semi-natural land (garrigue, maquis) would offset 3–4% of that CO₂ (1–8% across rates).

0 ha

Forest mapped on Gozo

None at CORINE's 25 ha scale. Malta's whole forest is 470 ha (FAO definition, 2025).

30%

Water already used

Malta's water exploitation index in 2023 (above 20% signals scarcity). In an arid trial, 42–70% of pines died within 20 years.

Not found

Indigenous-tree strategy

“Indigenous” appears once in 16 chapters: for farm crop varieties and livestock breeds.

FAIR TO SAY

The PN's environment chapter presents trees as a defence against heat, flooding and pollution, which this check does not assess. Afforestation can be a small part of a plan that cuts emissions; it cannot carry it.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ What share of Gozo's emissions trees should offset.

☐ The area, sites and species to be planted.

☐ Where the indigenous-tree strategy is set out.

☐ How plantations would be watered, sparing garrigue.